

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF
MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 6 OCTOBER 2026

A satellite image of the Strait of Hormuz, showing the Persian Gulf to the west and the Arabian Sea to the east. The strait is a narrow waterway between Iran and the Musandam Peninsula of Oman. The water is dark blue, and the surrounding land is a mix of brown and green. The image is cropped to focus on the strait.

TEHRAN SAYS IT IS SHUT. FOUR TRACKERS SAY IT IS OPEN (P3)

SINGAPORE

Four of five regions are Unhealthy this morning, and the law written for exactly this has never once been used

THE ATELIER

The stiffest tripod head ever measured costs \$335. A maker calls its own load ratings “proprietary”

SCREEN & SOUND

Two films opened one Metascore point apart. One took four times the other

THIS ISSUE • NO. 124

Contents

p3–4 The World — a blockade that exists in the communiqués and not in the cargo data; and one spokesman, two target counts
p5 Singapore — the haze has not broken, and the Act written for it has never been used
p6 The Atelier — tripods: the stiffest head measured costs \$335, and the grail is not stiffer
p7 Technology — a redaction that came off with a cursor
p8 The Home Lab — a merged speedup that was a regression on the reviewer’s own card
p9 The Kit — eight brain metrics, one of them a measurement
p10 The Good Life — one watch, five prices, and a ten per cent gap
p11 Screen & Sound — forty-five and forty-six, and twenty-four million dollars

p12–13 The Family Desk — two papers, and a policy with no defined outcome
p14 The Macro Desk — a soft payroll print that rallied stocks and not bonds
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — rockhounding and fossil hunting: the hobby whose hardest constraint is the law
p18 Fitness — the maintenance dose, and the ninety-seven per cent nobody mentions
p19–20 The Diary — three things on this page cannot be bought; and our own ledger barred three “new” restaurants
p21–23 The Long Read — Vanuatu: a country exporting the room it argues in
p24 The Last Word
No spine this issue — a straight news book, deliberately, after three themed ones

FROM THE DESK

“Science is built up of facts, as a house is built of stones; but an accumulation of facts is no more a science than a heap of stones is a house.”

Henri Poincaré, *La Science et l’Hypothèse* (1902)¹

Twelve desks is an accumulation. Today we have not tried to make it a house.

THE STRIP • AT MONDAY’S CLOSE

US 2-year	4.83%	▲ 5bp
US 10-year	5.311%	▲ 3.4bp
10-year breakeven	2.36%	flat
VWRA	\$193.84	▲ 0.57%
DXY	102.12	▲ 0.19%
USD/SGD	1.2794	flat
Brent	\$100.32	▼ 1.89%
Gold	\$4,139.75	▼ 0.01%
Bitcoin (intraday)	\$85,731	▼ 0.14%

Closes for Monday 5 October 2026; bitcoin is an intraday print, not a settle. Detail on **p14**.
 Not advice.²

THE ARCHIVE • TUESDAY — FOUR THINGS THIS MAGAZINE SAID IT WOULD COME BACK TO

No. 123 held the Brazilian first round open. It has landed: **47.03% to 45.16%**, with the run-off on 25 October (**p4**).

The Little India light-up dates have been unpublished since No. 121. They are out, and they correct a date circulating in the listings: Deepavali is **Sunday 8 November**, not the 7th (**p19**).

No. 123 settled the Singapore policy date at “not later than 14 October”. Re-read on the central bank’s own calendar this morning; it still says exactly that, and the Macroeconomic Review carries the same ceiling (**p14**).

And one correction we are issuing against other people’s arithmetic. A ten-year term premium of **1.45** is circulating for 1 October. The Federal Reserve’s own file says **0.9047** (**p14**).³

SOURCES ¹ Poincaré’s remark appears in *La Science et l’Hypothèse*, 1902, in the chapter on hypothesis in physics, in the standard English rendering. ² Levels at the close of Monday 5 October 2026 and, for bitcoin, an intraday print; every figure is sourced on **p14**, where the real-yield decomposition is shown as this desk’s own derivation from three published series. ³ Each item is checked against the primary source named on the page cross-referenced.

THE WORLD · HORMUZ, DAY TWO HUNDRED AND NINETEEN

Tehran says the strait is shut. Two cargo trackers, two investment banks and Saudi Arabia's own November price list say it is open

On the morning its chief executive called the world's spare supply "scarily thin", Aramco widened the discount it offers Asian refiners to a six-year low. Both statements came out of the same company, eight hours apart.

The blockade is in its eighth month and the argument about it has stopped being about politics. It is now an argument about measurement. On Sunday the speaker of Iran's parliament, **Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf**, said the strait "will not be opened until our seven conditions, based on the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding, are met." On Monday the commercial world published its count of what went through anyway.¹

The gap is not marginal. **Ali Fadavi**, deputy commander of the Revolutionary Guard, put current traffic at "three to four million barrels of oil per day" and called it negligible. **Kpler** has Middle East crude exports at a seven-day average of **18.3m barrels a day** on 30 September, above the pre-war average on fourteen days that month; **Vortexa**, over fourteen days of crude and condensate, has **18.6m**, above its ten-year seasonal average. **JPMorgan** puts Gulf throughput at **17.5m**, Goldman Sachs shipments at **98% of pre-war**. Fadavi's number is a fifth of the smallest of those.²

4.6×

HOW MUCH LARGER KPLER'S TRACKED CRUDE FIGURE IS THAN THE REVOLUTIONARY GUARD'S OWN — AND **6.1×** AT THE LOW END OF THE GUARD'S RANGE. MERIDIAN'S ARITHMETIC FROM THE TWO PUBLISHED NUMBERS²

Some of the spread is definitional, and Radio Free Europe's **Kian Sharifi** finds **40%** of Gulf crude now bypassing Hormuz through Saudi and Emirati pipelines. But nobody has published a transit count at the strait itself, the one number that would settle it.³

ABU DHABI — THE NATIONAL

The Gulf's own read is the most deflationary in the file: not scarcity, a price war. Aramco cut November Arab Light to Asia to **\$5 below the Oman-Dubai average**, a six-year low, widened from a \$2 discount in October — while raising Europe by \$3. "Oil flows rebound" is the headline; the Kingdom sold almost **100m barrels** to Asian buyers in mid-September.⁴

THE CHATTER · THE LOUDEST THING IS THE QUIET

In March, Hacker News ran *Hormuz Minesweeper — Are you tired of winning?* to **662 points and 452 comments**. Across 3–5 October its only Hormuz submission was the wire story on the G7's hundred million barrels: **three points, one comment**. Reddit was unreachable on every route, so nothing is claimed for it.⁵

"Emergency reserves might buy us a winter. They cannot fix long-term supply."

THE SCEPTIC · THREE NUMBERS FROM ONE SPEECH

Aramco's **Amin Nasser** told the Energy Intelligence Forum in London on Monday that the world entered the war with roughly **10bn barrels** of commercial inventory, that **more than 1bn** has been drawn down, and that **under 6bn** remains. Ten minus one is nine. His own prescription — **2m extra barrels a day for eighteen months** — comes to **1.09bn**, almost exactly the drawdown, and nothing like the four billion his first and third figures imply. The three reconcile only if they count different things, and the speech did not say which.⁶

SOURCES 1 Qalibaf quoted in a Reuters report read on Arab News, and in Al Jazeera's own account, both 4 October; neither enumerates the seven conditions, so this desk does not list them. Foreign Minister Araghchi's claim that the strait could reopen within seven days is in the Al Jazeera piece. 2 Fadavi, Kpler and Vortexa figures read on Al Jazeera, 5 October, and NBC News, 5 October; JPMorgan's throughput via Bloomberg on Rigzone, 3 October; Goldman's 98% in The National, 5 October. The multiples are this desk's own division of Kpler's 18.3m by the Guard's stated 3–4m. 3 Sharifi's count of at least 16.5m b/d leaving the Gulf 1–28 September, and the pipeline share, read on Eurasia Review, 3 October. **Held:** a Kpler figure for crude transiting the strait itself reached this desk as a search summary only and is not printed. 4 The National, 5 October, for the official selling prices and the September Asian sales. 5 Point and comment counts read through the Hacker News search API; the March threads are dated 22 and 31 March. Reddit returned nothing on any route from this environment. 6 Nasser's remarks read on Oilprice and on a Reuters copy, both 5 October; the barrel arithmetic is Meridian's, from his own two figures.

THE WORLD · THE OTHER CHOKEPOINT

Yemen's government says it has taken the heights above Bab el-Mandeb. The coalition spokesman gave two different target counts to two outlets on the same day

Al Jazeera, which carried both, printed the sentence that governs the whole file: it could not independently verify the battlefield reports. Neither can anyone else.

Six hundred miles south-west of the strait on p3 sits the other one. On Sunday **Rashad al-Alimi**, chairman of the ruling council in Aden, announced an offensive to retake all remaining Houthi-held ground, with Saudi-led air support. “Yemen will march towards a new dawn of freedom, peace and stability,” he said. By Monday government forces claimed Dhubab district and its airstrip, the positions overlooking **Bab el-Mandeb**, and the port of **Mokha**, some 45km north.¹

The coalition's spokesman, Maj Gen **Turki al-Malki**, described **100 fighter jets** flying round the clock. To The National he put the tally at **324 “high-value” targets destroyed**. In Al Jazeera's account of the same briefing he said only “hundreds”. One is a count, the other an adjective, and they came from one man on one day.²

217 → 647

SUSPECTED CHOLERA CASES IN THREE WEEKS, WITH **959 DEATHS** AMONG MORE THAN 5,000 CASUALTIES SINCE 6 AUGUST AND **NEARLY 200,000** DISPLACED — ATTRIBUTED BY THE NATIONAL TO WHO AND WFP. **SINGLE-SOURCED**: NO UN DOCUMENT WAS REACHABLE FROM THIS DESK³

WASHINGTON — VIA THE NATIONAL

Secretary of State **Marco Rubio** declines the military role and keeps the intelligence one: “Obviously the Saudis have come under Houthi attack and see the threat.” The United States is supplying targeting and intelligence and nothing that flies.²

SANAA — SABA, THE GOVERNMENT AGENCY

Names the units and the objective rather than the enemy's losses: the Homeland Shield Forces and the Giants Brigades “carried out a large-scale military operation with air cover”, and an unnamed army source says they advanced “cutting off supply lines and roads leading to Bab al-Mandeb.”⁴

THE CHATTER · THE SENTENCE EVERYONE ELSE LEAVES OUT

Al Jazeera's **Michael Appel**, on the advance: it “leaves tens of thousands with the prospect of continued displacement and hunger as a humanitarian crisis takes hold.” The channel then states flatly that it **could not independently verify the battlefield reports** — the standard disclaimer, and the only honest line in the file, since every territorial claim here comes from one of the two combatants' own agencies.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE TOLL NOBODY WILL RECONCILE

Twenty-four seafarers have been killed since the Gulf war began, a figure attributed to the International Maritime Organization on a Bloomberg wire. The IMO's own statement of 11 June counted **46 attacks and 14 deaths**. Ten more across four months is plausible; what nobody has published is the two numbers in one place, with the dates between them.⁵

IN BRIEF

Brasília. The Brazilian result we held open in No. 123 has landed: **Flávio Bolsonaro 47.03%** to **Lula's 45.16%** in Sunday's first round, turnout 78.92%. The run-off is **25 October**.⁶

Madrid. Pedro Sánchez called a snap general election for **29 November** after his housing decrees fell in the Congress on 2 October; his coalition holds 148 of 350 seats, and 176 is a majority.⁶

Stockholm. The Nobel in Physiology or Medicine went to **Karl Deisseroth, Peter Hegemann and Georg Nagel** for light-gated ion channels and optogenetics — a pulse of light switching one class of neuron on. The foundation's own site refused this desk, so the prize sum is not printed.⁶

Mekelle. Ethiopian federal forces re-entered the Tigrayan capital on 4 October after the TPLF said it had moved out; fighting resumed on 23 September, three and a half years after the Pretoria agreement.⁷

SOURCES 1 Al-Alimi's announcement and the claimed gains read on The National and Al Jazeera, 5 October; Wikipedia's current-events record dates the announcement to Sunday 4 October, which is why this page says Sunday and the claims run through Monday. 2 Al-Malki's 100 jets and the 324-target figure in The National, 5 October; Al Jazeera's version of the same briefing, same date, says “hundreds” and gives no number. Rubio quoted in The National. 3 Casualty, displacement and cholera figures read on The National, which attributes them to WHO and WFP; ReliefWeb returned 403 to every request from this desk, so no primary UN document was opened. **Treat as single-sourced**. 4 Saba's account and Appel's report read on Al Jazeera, 5 October, which carries the non-verification line in its own text. 5 The 24-seafarer figure on a Bloomberg report via Rigzone, 3 October; the IMO's 11 June count of 46 attacks and 14 deaths is recorded on the English Wikipedia campaign page and was not opened at an IMO domain. 6 Brazilian and Spanish results and the Nobel announcement read on the relevant English Wikipedia articles, which cite the wires; nobelprize.org returned 403, so no prize sum is printed. 7 Al Jazeera, 5 October.

SINGAPORE • THE AIR, AT FIVE O’CLOCK THIS MORNING

Four of five regions are in the Unhealthy band, the forecast is fair and warm with no rain in any period — and the government’s own guidance says you do not need a mask

The law written for exactly this, twelve years ago, has never been used. In February the minister told Parliament the haze had not reached levels that would warrant investigating under it.

The reading this desk pulled from the environment agency’s own feed at **05:00 this morning**, timestamped and pulled twice: 24-hour PSI of **132 central, 118 west, 111 east, 107 north**. Yesterday the central region touched **134 at eleven at night**, all five regions above a hundred at once. The forecast issued at 23:51 promises “Fair & Warm”, a high of **35°C**, light south-southeasterlies and no rain in any period to midnight tomorrow. Nothing in it clears the smoke.¹

The agency names the cause — dense smoke from southern Sumatra, with fires in Kalimantan — but published **no hotspot count** on any of the past three days, because “the full extent... could not be determined due to extensive cloud cover.”¹

300

THE PSI AT WHICH OFFICIAL GUIDANCE FIRST RECOMMENDS AN N95 FOR A HEALTHY ADULT OUTDOORS FOR SEVERAL HOURS. AT **132** THE SAME FRAMEWORK TELLS THE ELDERLY, PREGNANT WOMEN, CHILDREN AND ANYONE WITH LUNG OR HEART DISEASE TO CURTAIL ACTIVITY. BOTH ARE IN FORCE THIS MORNING²

THE SCEPTIC • TWELVE YEARS, NO PROSECUTIONS

Singapore passed the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act in **2014** to reach companies abroad whose fires foul its air. Asked about it in Parliament on **12 February**, the Minister for Sustainability and the Environment, **Grace Fu**, replied that “at this stage, the haze has not reached such levels which would warrant investigation” under it, and gave no enforcement figures.³

SINGAPORE • THE NATIONAL DIET SURVEY

Mean sodium reaches 4,000mg a day and 95% of residents are now over the limit — while the labelling meant to address it slips a year, to 2028

The health ministry published its two national surveys on Friday under the headline that Singaporeans are “embracing healthier lifestyles”. Every other measured dietary number went the wrong way: calories **2,360 to 2,460**, total fat **94g to 103g**, saturated fat at **35%** against a 30% ceiling, and seven in ten now eat out at least once a day. A plate of chicken rice has gone from **557 to 646 calories**. The labelling meant to address it slips to **2028**, a year late.⁴

THE CHATTER • THE CLINICIANS, NOT THE RELEASE

The headline that activity is up — **87.3%** getting enough — is the one number in the set that is self-reported, and the ministry’s own clinicians say so. Professor **Tai E Shyong** of the National University Hospital notes people “tend to over-report moderate- and high-intensity activity”, and warns rising sodium “will see a corresponding increase in severe, life-altering complications... like chronic kidney disease and strokes”. Reddit was unreachable on every route this morning.⁵

SOURCES 1 Readings pulled directly from the National Environment Agency’s real-time PSI and PM2.5 feeds on data.gov.sg, reading timestamped 06:00 SGT 6 October 2026 and queried twice; daily maxima computed by this desk from the hourly series. Advisory language and the task-force composition from NEA’s own haze situation updates of 3, 4 and 5 October and its release of 4 September, all read at source. No 6 October advisory had been published at the time of writing. 2 Mask and activity thresholds as published in the 4 September release. 3 Grace Fu’s oral reply of 12 February 2026, read at source on the ministry’s site; Tan and Mohd Hazmi quoted in an Agence France-Presse report of 4 Ministry of Health release of 3 October and the two national surveys behind it, read at source; the surveys’ sample sizes are not stated in the release. Dish-level calorie figures as reported by Mothership, 4 October. 5 Tai and Tan quoted in AsiaOne, 4 October, read at source.

THE ATELIER • TRIPODS AND TRIPOD HEADS

The stiffest ball head anyone has measured costs three hundred and thirty-five dollars. The grail costs one thousand seven hundred and fourteen, and is not stiffer — it is geared

A maker told the one man who tests these things that its load ratings are “proprietary”. The layer count printed on a carbon leg is a Chinese retail convention. Almost nothing on the box is a measurement.

One man publishes numbers for this category and nobody else does. The Center Column measures rotational stiffness by exciting a locked tripod with a torsion spring. Start with the material. Carbon fibre’s modulus is quoted at **181 GPa** against aluminium’s **69** — but real tripod composite measures as low as **30 to 50**, worse than aluminium. “Carbon fibre” is a category, not a specification.¹

The one clean comparison is Manfrotto’s 055, sold in both materials: carbon **1,289 Nm** against aluminium’s **877.8**. Carbon wins. But the aluminium tripods plot on a tidy weight-to-stiffness line and the carbon ones scatter badly — and that scatter is the layup lie, measured. What decides a leg is the wall thickness and outer diameter of its bottom section, which nobody prints. What they do print — eight layers, ten layers — is a retail convention.¹

THE SCEPTIC • “THERE IS NO INDUSTRY STANDARD”

Manfrotto told that tester, on the record, that “**there is no industry standard for determining the weight capacity of tripods and heads**” and that its own method is “**proprietary and I am not permitted to go into detail about it.**” Plotted against measured stiffness, any rating covers a spread of about **five to one**. It cannot work, for a physical reason: tripod vibration is predominantly **rotational**, so what matters is moment of inertia.²

13,253

NM/RAD FOR THE **FEISOL CB-70D**, THE STIFFEST BALL HEAD EVER MEASURED — **\$334.95** TODAY.³

Another myth dies on the same bench. Twist locks against flip locks, on the one model sold both ways: **171 against 173 Nm/rad** in yaw — “all of the measurements are within error of each other” —. The

SOURCES 1 thecentercolumn.com, carbon-versus-aluminium article and methodology pages, read at source; the 055 pair is the only same-model two-material comparison published. The layer-count convention reached this desk as a search summary of a forum thread that then refused the request, and is printed as a trade convention, attributed to nobody. 2 The same tester on head and tripod weight ratings, read at source, including the Manfrotto correspondence quoted verbatim. 3 Head stiffness from his rankings, read at source; the CB-70D price at feisol.net, the RRS and Arca-Swiss prices at their own sites and the Singapore price at photospheresg.com, all 6 October 2026. 4 Twist-versus-flip and centre-column measurements, same source. He does not test dust ingress; the sealing argument is reasoning, not measurement. 5 Videndum plc Annual Report and Accounts 2025, downloaded and read: subsidiaries, manufacturing geography, the Shenzhen office, the Costa Rica tax line and the March 2026 equity raise. 6 RRS’s own knowledge-base page on the dovetail; forum quotations from talkphotography.co.uk, attributed there by handle. Reddit, DPReview, Cloudy Nights and Fred Miranda all returned 403. 7 reallyrightstuff.com, adorama.com and arca-swiss-usa.com; Adorama lists the TVC-33 Mk2 as no longer available. The sand warning is Mike Kelley’s, at APALMANAC.

real argument there is sealing and service, which on a Singapore beach is the better argument anyway.⁴

THE WHITE-LABEL TRUTH • A FRENCH BADGE, AN ITALIAN FACTORY, A SHENZHEN OFFICE

Videndum of Bury St Edmunds owns **Manfrotto**, **Gitzo**, **Sachtler** and **O’Connor**. Gitzo’s French company survives as a holding shell; the tripods have been Italian since 2005. Revenue fell **£306.9m to £228.3m** in two years; in March it raised **£85m at 1.35 pence** a share.⁵

THE CHATTER • THE STANDARD NOBODY WROTE

Really Right Stuff’s own knowledge base says it plainly: Arca-Swiss **never published a dovetail standard**, so RRS wrote one — 35mm, 45 degrees —. On brands the forums split: a British marque is “knock offs of a knock off” to one poster, while two others praise its anodising.⁶

THREE TIERS, AND WHERE THE CURVE FLATTENS

The grail, \$1,225 to \$1,714. An RRS Versa TVC-33 Mk2 and an Arca-Swiss C1 Cube. The Cube buys geared, backlash-free, repeatable motion — a different capability, not a stiffer one. It also buys **exposed gears that ingest sand.**⁷

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Mattresses & slat bases — latex against pocket springs, and what tropical humidity does to both.

Binoculars (prisms, coatings and the badge tax) — roof against porro, phase coating, and who actually grinds the glass.

Espresso machines (the boiler, not the badge) — heat exchanger against dual boiler against lever, and where the curve goes flat.

TECHNOLOGY • LINCOLN, NEBRASKA

Google argued that how much water and power its data centre uses were trade secrets. The state published the report with the figures blacked out, and a reporter dragged a cursor across them

The numbers underneath turn out to be unremarkable. The fight to keep them was not: the same claim was filed over all three of the company's Nebraska sites.

Nebbraska's governor, **Jim Pillen**, signed an executive order on 20 July requiring the state's data centres to report what they consume. The first reports were due on 30 September. The department published the report with black boxes over the numbers. A reporter at the local television station highlighted the boxes, copied, and pasted.¹

What came out: **13.299 megagallons of water a year** and a **52.65-megawatt** peak electricity demand. The water figure is about **36,400 gallons a day**, or roughly twenty Olympic pools a year — modest enough to suggest the site is largely air-cooled. The power figure is the one that matters: run flat out, 52.65MW is **461 gigawatt-hours** a year.²

3

NEBRASKA DATA CENTRES OVER WHICH THE SAME TRADE-SECRET CLAIM WAS FILED. THE EXEMPTION WAS NOT ARGUED FOR ONE UNUSUAL SITE; IT WAS THE DEFAULT POSTURE FOR THE COMPANY'S WHOLE PRESENCE IN THE STATE¹

THE CHATTER • 511 POINTS, 666 COMMENTS

The story was four days old before it reached Hacker News, where it ran to **511 points and 666 comments** on 4 October.¹

TECHNOLOGY • THE VERDICTS ARRIVE

Three days after the sovereign model landed, the count of independent evaluations is still zero —

but an outsider has now measured one of its claims and found it understated

We carried **Kolibri-1** in No. 122 at release, with nothing checked. The delta is that the first outside work has been done, and it cuts both ways. A teardown ran the model's own tokeniser against the German constitution and got **35,190 tokens to GPT-5's 41,482** — a **17.9% reduction**, against the maker's claimed 11.2%. Everything else came out worse than the launch framing: closed-book knowledge last of twelve; tool calling **39.8 against 58.2**; mid-context recall at 128k **67.9 against 89.9**. His summary: it “computes like a 3.5 billion parameter model but needs the memory of a 78 billion parameter one.”³

THE SCEPTIC • THE OPPONENTS ARE FROM THE SPRING

Jakob Steinschaden, in Vienna, does not dispute the figures — he disputes the field. “All three comparison models date from the spring. Since then, Chinese labs in particular have released considerably stronger open-weight models.” On one public index those three score 11 to 18; **Qwen3.8-Flash-Next scores 40**. His placing of Kolibri at 15–20 is an estimate, because it still has no row there. Sharper: on the maker's own harness and in its own language, a dense **27B Qwen beats it, 79.9 to 70.8** — printed in Kolibri's own table.⁴

STILL ON THE BENCH

Home Assistant is renaming Home Assistant Cloud to **Home Assistant Link**, official at the 2026.12 release, with feedback open now. No pricing change was announced and no subscriber count was given.⁵

SOURCES 1 Reporting by the Lincoln television station 10/11 Now, published 30 September 2026, read at source: the executive order of 20 July, the Agate LLC filing, the statutes cited (Neb. Rev. Stat. §§81-1527 and 84-712.05, and Title 115 Chapter 2 of the administrative code), the three-site scope, the redaction method and the records request. Hacker News point and comment counts read through its search API, 4 October. 2 Water and power figures as published in that report. The per-day water figure and the 461GWh annual-draw figure are *Meridian's* arithmetic from the two published numbers; 461GWh assumes continuous peak draw, which no data centre sustains, so read it as a ceiling. 3 The independent teardown published at tejas, read at source, with its tokeniser test on the German basic law and the benchmark comparisons it draws from Kolibri's own technical report. 4 Steinschaden at trendingtopics.eu, 3 October, read at source; his byline discloses AI co-production. The German comparison was traced to the maker's own published table. **Held:** Kolibri still has no independent evaluation. 5 The Norwegian proposal read in British and American coverage; the Home Assistant renaming on the project's own blog, 2 October, which publishes no prices.

THE HOME LAB · WHAT A MERGE ACTUALLY PROVES

A sparse-attention patch was merged yesterday with a measured fifteen per cent gain on the author's cards — and the reviewer who approved it had found it two and a half times slower on his

Both numbers are in the thread. Neither is wrong. The threshold heuristic doing the real work was tuned on hardware that is not yours.

Pull request 29639 to llama.cpp, opened 29 September and merged at **08:37 UTC on 5 October**, fixes something real: sparse flash attention previously worked only with half-precision caches, so a quantised model ran dense attention over the whole context even though only about **two thousand cells** are actually kept. The author measured decode on his own AMD cards — 32k context **38.9 to 39.7 tokens a second**, 64k **27.9 to 32.3**, a 15.6% gain, and after a second commit about 15% at 128k too.¹

Then the Vulkan backend's most senior reviewer, who works at the chip company, approved the code and wrote this underneath it: "The code looks reasonable to me, but perf with sparse is much worse than without on my system, in coopmat1 mode." On his card, at a short context, sparse took **27.32 microseconds against dense's 11.35 — 2.4 times slower**. It crosses over only further out: at 32,768 it is **39.72 against 75.66**. The patch ships with a **sixteen-fold** context-to-kept ratio before it engages, and that threshold is the whole product.¹

2 of 7

REPRODUCTIONS OF THE WEEK'S OTHER STORY THAT FOLLOWED A PROTOCOL — THREE RUNS, MEDIAN AND RANGE, PROMPT AND DECODE SEPARATED. THE OTHER FIVE ARE SELF-REPORTS WITH HARDWARE ATTACHED. THE DISTINCTION IS THE REPOSITORY'S OWN, WRITTEN INTO ITS CONTRIBUTION GUIDE²

That other story is **Strata**, an inference engine that reached **907 points and 407 comments** on Hacker News on 4 October for running a 125-billion-parameter model on a twelve-gigabyte card. the author records that greedy output is not byte-deterministic by default — **one identical answer in four repeats** with every switch set, two in four with the defaults. Its own measured table peaks at **93.0**

tokens a second. The headline that carried it said a hundred.²

THE CHATTER · A NERFED HUNDRED AND TWENTY-FIVE BILLION

kennywinker states the trade cleanly: minus ten per cent accuracy, "probably more like -20% in reality", only matters if you could have run it at full — and before this, under 24GB, the best was a 27B at four bits. "Now you can run a nerfed 125B parameter model on under \$800 of hardware, and it beats a less-nerfed 27b model." Reddit refused every route, so none of this is from r/LocalLLaMA.³

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY PUBLISHES THE ACCURACY

tcident states the rule of the week: "All of these projects targeting low spec systems and '100 tok/s' are the same 2 bit quant without much else. Conveniently none of them include any mention of accuracy in their published numbers. 4 bit is the floor." **mapontosevenths** gives the information-theoretic version: without post-quantisation recovery training you lose "just 20% randomly" and do not choose which. **esafak** asks what nobody answered, here or in the sovereign-model thread on **p7** — should benchmarks not be published *at the quantisation people actually run*? The charge lands on the genre more than this repository, which does publish its perplexity cost.³

STILL ON THE BENCH

Valve at XDC. Timur Kristóf presented work reviving decade-old AMD GCN graphics cards on Linux through the open Vulkan driver — 489 points on 3 October. The ~30% figure circulating alongside it belongs to a different article this desk could not open, and is not printed.⁴

And the week's best counter-example to 29639: one of Strata's two protocol-grade reproductions ran a 125B model across **two AMD Instinct MI50s** — 2018 cards, on a community build — split across both. The hardware the patches are tuned on and the hardware they run on have never been further apart.²

SOURCES 1 Pull request 29639 in the llama.cpp repository, read at source: the description, the author's own benchmark table, the eval counts, the sixteen-fold threshold and the reviewer's comment and figures, quoted as written. Merge time as recorded on the pull request. 2 The Strata repository's README, DETAILS.md and COMMUNITY_BENCHMARKS.md, all read at source, for the throughput table, the 4-bit cache perplexity cost, the determinism measurements and the two documented reproductions; the Hacker News point and comment counts read through its search API. 3 Comments on the Hacker News thread of 3 Comments on the Hacker News thread of 4 October, read through its search API and attributed by handle; per-comment scores are unavailable there, so none is given. Reddit was unreachable on every route. 4 Phoronix, 3 October, read at source; the performance figure it refers to sits in a second article that returned 403, so it is held.

THE KIT · THE REVIEWS LAND

The five-hundred-dollar headphone that reads your brain has eight metrics on its box. One of them is a real measurement, and the accuracy figure everyone quotes belongs to a different device from 2021

We carried it at announcement in No. 122 with nothing validated. The first hands-on reviews are in, and so is a named EEG researcher who says electrodes over hair give very poor data.

The **Neurable One** is a twelve-channel dry electroencephalography rig in the body of a premium noise-cancelling headphone: six sensors a side sewn through each ear pad, **40mm beryllium drivers**, six microphones, **22 hours** of audio or 12 with the electrodes live, 345 grams, **US\$499**, shipping to its first seven hundred customers. There is no subscription and the headphones work without the app. There is also, per the maker's own regulatory line, no medical claim: it "is not a medical device and does not diagnose, treat, or monitor any health condition."¹

What it sells on top of the audio is eight numbers — Brain Age, Brain Battery, Speed, Focus, Load, Stress, Sleepiness and Alpha Peak Frequency. Exactly one of those, the last, is an established and measurable quantity, and IEEE Spectrum's reviewer got a plausible **10Hz** from it. The **80% ± 4.1%** accuracy figure circulating with the product is not this product's: it comes from a 2021 preprint on the company's earlier prototype, 132 participants and 337 sessions, run by the company. **No accuracy figure has been published for the Neurable One.**²

16 vs 24

BITS OF EEG RESOLUTION — THE FIRST FROM THE MAKER'S OWN SPECIFICATION PAGE, THE SECOND FROM THE TRADE PRESS REPORTING THE SAME PRODUCT. FOR AN ELECTROENCEPHALOGRAPH THE BIT DEPTH IS NOT COSMETIC, AND NOBODY HAS RECONCILED THE TWO¹

THE SCEPTIC · A NAMED RESEARCHER, NOT A COLUMNIST

Arnaud Delorme, a research scientist at the University of California, San Diego, and one of the people behind the toolchain the EEG field actually runs on, told IEEE Spectrum two things. First: "Electrodes placed over hair tend to have very poor quality data in dry EEG systems." Second, with his own emphasis: "in EEG, it's all about data quality." He adds that he worries overpromising will damage the field and produce another hype cycle. The electrodes here are in the ear pads, which sit on hair; the reviewer, **Gwendolyn Rak**, reports that "several times when I put them on, the app would tell me to adjust the fit—even when they felt snug", and that the longer-horizon metrics need about a week to calibrate.²

THE CHATTER · REVIEWERS, BUT NO OWNERS

There is nothing here to report, and that is the finding. Hacker News has no thread on it; its most recent Neurable item is an Ask HN from April 2025 — **two points, zero replies**. Reddit refused this desk. What does exist is reviewer caution: **James Pero** at Gizmodo, who has used EEG sleep-tracking earbuds that "weren't always able to accurately track my level of sleep", calls at-home EEG "more hit-or-miss". One detail nobody markets: raw EEG goes to the company's cloud with **eighteen-month retention**.³

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Huawei FreeBuds Neo, ¥699. Launched 1 October: **4.8g** an earbud, **IP55**, 6.5 hours with cancellation on and 40 with the case. Cancellation is claimed at **30dB average** across 50Hz–20kHz — and the **Singapore page adds a 55dB peak** the **China page does not**. Nothing has been independently measured, four days in.⁴

Held, a fourth issue running: no Singapore price exists for any of the three. The Neurable's own checkout page says "US only"; Huawei has built a full Singapore product page with a Buy button and no number behind it.⁴

SOURCES 1 Neurable's own checkout and specification page, read at source 6 October, for price, sensor count, drivers, battery, mass, availability and the eight metrics; the 16-bit figure is from that page and the 24-bit figure from Notebookcheck's 2 October report, also read at source, which likewise carries the regulatory disclaimer and the cloud-retention term. 2 IEEE Spectrum's hands-on by Gwendolyn Rak, read at source, for Delorme's remarks and the fit and alpha-peak observations; the provenance of the 80% figure from neurofounders.co, 1 October, read at source. **Held**: an internal comparison against a clinical system is referred to in secondary coverage but no published study was found. 3 Hacker News searched through its API; the April 2025 thread and its score are as recorded there. Gizmodo, 2 October, read at source. Reddit returned 403 on every route. 4 Huawei's own China and Singapore product pages, both read at source 6 October; every figure is the manufacturer's and none has been independently tested. 5 MINIX's own product page and its earlier blog post, both read at source; a higher listed price circulating this month comes from a site that returned a payment wall and is not printed.

THE GOOD LIFE · ONE WATCH, FIVE PRICES

Omega put the Bond Seamaster on sale yesterday in six countries. Strip the tax out of each and the American list is ten per cent above the German one

The press release carries no prices at all. They live only on regional retail pages, which is exactly how a ten per cent gap goes unremarked.

Reference **210.30.42.20.03.004**, on sale from 5 October: steel, **42.00mm** across and **14.23mm** deep, 50mm lug to lug, a Grade 5 titanium bezel ring over a blue laser-engraved wave dial, a gun-barrel motif at twelve, a brushed steel mesh bracelet, 157 grams, 300 metres with a helium valve, and the calibre **8806** at **3.5Hz** — **25,200 vibrations an hour** — with **55 hours of reserve**, certified to 15,000 gauss. It is not limited. The companion Spectre reference swaps the titanium for black ceramic.¹

Now the prices, each read on Omega's own national page: **US\$8,600** before sales tax; **€8,300** in Germany and **€8,400** in France, both inclusive; **£7,200** in Britain and **CHF 7,200** in Switzerland, both inclusive. The two euro figures differ only by the VAT rates behind them. Strip every tax out and convert at the European Central Bank's reference rates for the same day and the European prices sit within **2.6%** of one another — while the American one lands **10.1%** above Germany's. Omega's own list implies a dollar-euro rate of **1.233** on a day the central bank fixed it at **1.1204**.²

\$S11,010

WHAT THE AMERICAN EX-TAX PRICE CONVERTS TO AT THAT DAY'S REFERENCE RATE, AGAINST **\$S10,005** FOR THE GERMAN EX-VAT ONE — BEFORE SINGAPORE'S 9% GST. OMEGA PUBLISHES **NO SINGAPORE PRICE**: THE LOCAL PAGE REDIRECTS TO THE AMERICAN ONE. MERIDIAN'S ARITHMETIC²

THE CHATTER · AND IT IS NOT ABOUT THE MONEY

Hodinkee, Reddit, Watchuseek and the Omega forums all refused this desk, so the only open comment thread reachable was Monochrome's, parsed from the page. Four of five voices are negative and none of them complains about price. **CT79**, timestamped 16:09: "this gets kind of old. There is nothing left in this model line which could be milked any further. Omega should finally release a smaller seamaster model... anything between 37 and 39mm would be great." **MS**: "Who are they making these for?" The one owner in the thread, **Ed**, dived with two Seamasters and likes the edition: "too rich for me." Five people, one site, one day — not a verdict, but the complaint is consistent and it is about size.³

THE SCEPTIC · THIRTEEN HUNDRED DOLLARS FOR A DIAL

Brandon Moore, at SJX, puts the number on it: the steel Bond model "commands a US\$1,300 premium relative to the standard Seamaster Diver 300M in the same configuration." That buys an engraved dial, a titanium bezel ring, a decorated rotor and a box; the movement is the one Omega already sells across the line. He notes the case is **0.75mm thicker** than the editions it follows, by a maker that "often gets criticised for making overly thick watches". And 42 by 14.23 on a mesh bracelet is not a watch that vanishes under a cuff at thirty-five degrees.⁴

ALSO

Shanling M7T Master, ¥197,010 including tax, out 9 October. Two AK4498EX converters and a separate AK4191 modulator, **two JAN6418 vacuum tubes** with a switch, and **1,020mW** into 32 ohms balanced in transistor mode against **990mW** in tube mode — the valves cost about three per cent of the output. 319.8 grams, 14.5 hours single-ended. Single-sourced: one Japanese outlet carried it, and the measurement forums had nothing.⁵

The 77 sets. Each steel-and-platinum-gold pair is numbered to 77 — the only limitation anywhere in the launch, and the reason the press release leads on them rather than on the watch most people will buy.¹

SOURCES 1 Omega's own product page for reference 210.30.42.20.03.004 and its press release of 5 October, both read at source, for every dimension, material, calibre figure and the set limitation; the vibrations-per-hour figure is the arithmetic conversion of the stated 3.5Hz. 2 Prices read on Omega's American, German, French, British and Swiss pages on 6 October 2026; the Singapore locale redirects to the American one. Tax stripped at each country's published rate and converted at the European Central Bank's daily reference rates for 5 October 2026, read at source. The comparison and both Singapore-dollar figures are Meridian's own arithmetic from those two sets of published numbers. **Note:** figures circulating in the trade press on 3 Comments parsed from the Monochrome Watches article of 5 October, read at source and quoted with their timestamps. Hodinkee, Reddit, Watchuseek and OmegaForums each refused this desk. 4 Brandon Moore at SJX, 6 October, read at source. 5 AV Watch, 2 October, read at source; no second outlet and no measurement thread was found.

SCREEN & SOUND · WEEKEND FORTY

Two wide releases opened into near-identical critical indifference — forty-five and forty-six out of a hundred. One took four times the other

The matching scores conceal opposite distributions: critics split hard on one film and were uniformly unmoved by the other. The audience ignored the distinction entirely.

The industry weekend was Friday 2 to Sunday 4 October. **Verity**, the Colleen Hoover adaptation, opened on 3,510 screens and took **\$32,618,776 — \$9,293** a screen. **Digger**, the Alejandro G. Iñárritu picture, opened on 3,321 and took **\$8,000,000, or \$2,409** a screen. Their Metascores are **45** and **46**. One point apart; twenty-four and a half million dollars apart.¹

The near-identical averages hide opposite shapes. On the Tomatometer, **Digger** reads **51%** from **271** reviews — a genuinely divided room — while **Verity** reads **33%** from **144**. Half as many critics bothered with the film that won. The aggregate flattens a split verdict and a shrugged one into the same number. The weekend's whole top ten took **\$98,532,049** across 65 reporting films.¹

\$858m

THE GAP BETWEEN TWO TRACKERS' CUMULATIVE FIGURE FOR THE SAME RE-RELEASED FILM. ONE IS COUNTING THE 2026 RUN; THE OTHER IS FOLDING IN THE 2019 ORIGINAL. ANYONE QUOTING THE LARGER NUMBER HAS MISREAD A COLUMN²

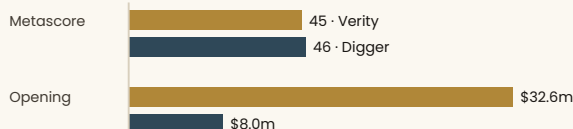
THE CHATTER · ONE FILM IS ARGUED ABOUT, THE OTHER IS JOKED ABOUT

Reddit refused this desk; Letterboxd did not. On **Digger**, the filmmaker **Anurag Kashyap** gives it five stars: "Wild theatrical performances, wild filmmaking, I don't understand why are cinephiles so divided over it." **Jake**, four stars: "Despite all the negative reactions to **Digger**, I don't think anyone hates **Digger** as much as **Digger** hates **Digger**." **Patrick Willems**: "Started off aggressively annoying, and then gradually kind of almost won me over?" On **Verity**, the register changes completely — **Yashley**, three stars: "Anne Hathaway is working overtime just to make Robert Pattinson look unemployed." Nobody is fighting about **Verity**. That asymmetry is the gross gap in miniature.³

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE AGGREGATE MEASURED

Digger opened on 3,321 screens and took **\$2,409** from each. That is not a divisive-film number; it is an indifference number, and no score predicted it. Say plainly what the weekend demonstrates: a one-point difference in a critic aggregate carried no information about what happened at the box office, and the two films' review counts — 271 against 144 — predicted the result better than their scores did. Rotten Tomatoes' own consensus on **Digger** calls it "a bold swing of the shovel... that misses as often as it strikes gold", which is at least honest about the variance.¹

ONE POINT APART, FOUR TIMES THE GROSS



Bars to scale within each pair. Sources: Metacritic and Box Office Mojo, weekend 40.

Meridian original.

The aggregate and the box office, drawn to the same scale within each pair. A one-point difference in critical average sat beside a twenty-four-and-a-half-million-dollar difference in opening gross.

SOUND

Eighty-three places, in week fifty-one. Taylor Swift's *The Life of a Showgirl* went from **No. 84 to No. 1** on the British albums chart dated 2 October, on the expanded edition and the album's first anniversary — its fifth non-consecutive week at the top, and the second Swift album to return to No. 1 on its anniversary. She took the singles chart the same week.⁴

And the number nobody published. The chart compiler gave no units figure for this week. The **423,000** in circulation is the October 2025 opening week, and is not this week's. Billboard's own chart was behind a paywall that returned a payment demand to this desk.⁴

New entries at two and three: Keo's *Put A Smile On For Me* and Nothing But Thieves' *Stray Dogs*; Olivia Rodrigo holds at four in week sixteen.⁴

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend 40 chart and The Numbers' chart for the weekend of 2 October, both read at source and in agreement on all ten titles and their order; Metacritic and Rotten Tomatoes pages for both films, each opened individually, for the scores and review counts and the Digger consensus. Per-screen figures are this desk's division of the published gross by the published screen count. 2 The two trackers' cumulative columns for the re-released title differ by that amount because one counts the re-release and the other the lifetime total; both were read at source. The two also differ by \$588,000 on the weekend's winner, a studio estimate against an actual. 3 Reviews read on Letterboxd and quoted verbatim with their authors as given there. Reddit returned 403 on every route. 4 The Official Charts Company's albums chart dated 2 October and its own news item of the same day, both read at source; the 423,000 figure is the October 2025 opening week. **Held:** no units figure for the current week has been published, and Billboard's chart was paywalled.

THE FAMILY DESK • TWO PAPERS, ONE DAY

The two best-designed studies of adolescents and social media published this year came out on the same Wednesday, and both found effects an order of magnitude smaller than the conversation assumes

One followed nine thousand seven hundred children across four years. The other took forty-four thousand daily observations. Neither supports the sentence a worried parent wants.

Both appeared in the *Journal of Adolescent Health* on **30 September**. The first, by Tang and colleagues, runs **9,747 adolescents** through the big American brain-development cohort across three waves — enrolled at nine or ten, followed at about twelve, and again at about fourteen. That middle wave is the band a child born in July 2014 sits in now. The method is a random-intercept cross-lagged panel model, which is the serious end of observational design: it separates change within a person from differences between people.¹

And the finding, stated with its size. More browsing at baseline predicted **reduced cognitive control two years later at $\beta = -0.06$** ; reduced cognitive control predicted **more depressive symptoms two years after that, also at $\beta = -0.06$** . In girls, more baseline screen time predicted depressive symptoms at $\beta = 0.05$, rising to between **0.09 and 0.13** on the later paths. A beta of 0.06 is on the order of **four-tenths of one per cent** of variance. The pathway is detectable in nine thousand seven hundred children and invisible in any one of them.¹

37.0%

THE SHARE OF ADOLESCENTS FOR WHOM SOCIAL-MEDIA USE HAD A POSITIVE EFFECT ON STRESS IN A 100-DAY DIARY STUDY — **14.2% NEGATIVE**, AND ROUGHLY HALF ESSENTIALLY NOTHING. GENDER, AGE AND TRAIT RESILIENCE DID **NOT** PREDICT WHICH GROUP A CHILD WAS IN. THE AUTHORS LOOKED²

The second paper is the more unusual. Siebers and colleagues followed **479 adolescents for a hundred days**, gathering **44,211 completed observations** — intensive longitudinal data rather than a one-shot survey. The average daily effect of social-media use on stress was $\beta = 0.03$, which the authors themselves call negligible. But the average conceals the whole story, and the effect grows with the window it is

measured over: **weekly 0.05, fortnightly 0.07, monthly 0.13**. The useful question for a parent of a twelve-year-old is not whether social media harms adolescents. It is whether this particular child is one of the thirty-seven per cent — and the authors say plainly that nothing they measured will tell you.²

THE SCEPTIC • AND THE PUSHBACK ON THE SCEPTICS

The standing contrarian position is **Candice Odgers**,³ whose team argued in *Frontiers in Developmental Psychology* that the evidence for restricting adolescents' social media shows “weak, negligible, and mixed effects”, with forty per cent of studies reporting harm from the restriction itself. This week's betas are her point, made again. But Spain's science media centre published named dissent alongside it, and it is specific. **José César Perales** of the University of Granada calls it a narrative review lacking systematic rigour and notes that **all the restriction studies it examined used adults, not adolescents** — which is a direct hit on its relevance to a secondary-school child. **Natalia Martín-María**: “Lack of evidence doesn't necessarily mean something is ineffective.” **Paloma Llana**: “Using supposed lack of scientific evidence as a pretext for simply doing nothing is a mistake.” Both halves are right, which is the honest position: nobody has the evidence a parent actually wants.³

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE DESIGNS CANNOT DO

Neither paper licenses a causal claim, and neither pretends to. Tang's exposure is **self-reported by the child**, the symptoms **reported by the parent**; screen time was never checked against a device log. “Cognitive control” here means performance on two reaction-time tasks, not attention in a classroom, and the paper does not claim otherwise. In girls the direction is partly circular — symptoms predicted more screen time, which predicted more symptoms — so what is reported is a loop, not an arrow. **General guidance, not medical advice.**¹

SOURCES 1 Tang, Leung, Prasad, Busso and Warren, “Longitudinal Relations Among Adolescents' Cognitive Control, Social Media Use, Anxiety, and Depressive Symptoms”, *Journal of Adolescent Health*, published 30 September 2026; abstract retrieved from the National Library of Medicine and read at source, for the sample, the waves, the model and every coefficient. The variance interpretation of a standardised beta is this desk's own arithmetic. 2 Siebers, Beyens, Keijsers, Valkenburg and van der Wal, same journal and date, abstract read at source, for the 479 participants, the 44,211 observations, the person-specific split and the timescale series. 3 Neff Lind and colleagues, led by Odgers, in *Frontiers in Developmental Psychology*, a Perspective rather than a systematic review; it and the named responses were read through Science Media Centre España's package of 29 May 2026, which is four months old and printed here as context.

THE FAMILY DESK • THREE TERMS IN

Singapore's secondary schools have kept phones in lockers through every school hour since January. Ten months on, no outcome has been defined, measured or published

The ministry told Parliament it had shared practices from schools that saw “positive outcomes”. The reply names no metric, no baseline and no reporting date.

The rule itself is clear enough. From January, the secondary-school guideline on phones and smartwatches extended from lesson time to **all school hours** — the ministry’s own release spells it out: “including recess, co-curricular activities, supplementary/enrichment/remedial lessons, etc.” Devices go in lockers or bags. The same month, the default sleep setting on school-issued learning devices moved from **11.00pm to 10.30pm**, with parents who had chosen looser after-school settings “strongly encouraged” to match it. Smartwatches are in scope; one payment-only watch is permitted and a named rival is not, because it has “smartwatch-like features”.¹

What the release does not contain is a single number. No baseline screen-time figure, no student survey percentage, no sleep data, no count of schools already doing it. The rationale — that screen use “has been shown to displace important activities such as sleep, physical activity and social interactions” — carries no citation. Asked in Parliament on **13 January** about emergency contact and teacher workload, the ministry said it had shared good practices from schools that had seen “**positive outcomes**”. The phrase appears without a metric, an instrument, a baseline, a timeline or a date on which anything will be reported.²

3

SCHOOL TERMS THE POLICY HAS NOW RUN. A CHILD WHO ENTERED SECONDARY 1 THIS JANUARY HAS LIVED UNDER IT FOR HER ENTIRE SECONDARY CAREER, AND NOTHING HAS BEEN PUBLISHED TO SAY WHETHER IT WORKED²

THE CHATTER • AND THE FOLLOW-UP THAT NEVER CAME

Before the rule took effect, broadcasters interviewed parents. **Ms Yvette Lim**, whose daughter was then entering Secondary 1: “In fact, I have also learnt of parents who encourage their kids, teach them how to work [around the rules].” **Mr Kelvin Choo**, 60, with five sons: “who’s going to be in charge to ensure that their phones are off or in the locker?” **Mr Jason Chew**, with daughters of twelve and thirteen: “that bond is also a bit affected.” Every one of those interviews is from **December 2025**, before the policy started. The absence of a December 2026 version of that article is this page’s point.³

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT A REAL EVALUATION WOULD NEED

None of this says the rule is wrong. A reasonable person can believe phones in lockers is good policy on first principles and still notice that it was introduced without a single pre-registered outcome. What an evaluation would require is not exotic: a baseline measure taken before January, the same measure now, a comparison group of some kind — schools that adopted it earlier would do — and a published date. The research on **p12** is the reason this matters. The honest effect sizes in that literature are **small enough** that a policy’s real effect could be anything from meaningful to nil, and no amount of shared good practice distinguishes those two. A ministry that can count screening uptake to a tenth of a percentage point can count this.¹

FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD, WHAT THE EVIDENCE ACTUALLY SUPPORTS

Sleep is the one with the big effect size — which is why the 10.30pm device default is the more defensible half of January’s change, and the half nobody argued about.¹

The diary study’s practical advice writes itself: you cannot tell from age, sex or temperament whether your child is in the affected third. You can only watch the child. A hundred days of observation beat a hundred headlines.⁴

General guidance, not medical advice. Nothing on these two pages is a diagnosis or a treatment plan, and neither paper measured one.

SOURCES 1 Ministry of Education press release of 30 November 2025 announcing the January 2026 measures, read at source and parsed from the live page: the extension to all school hours, the quoted scope, the device sleep-hour change and the smartwatch treatment. The release contains no statistics; that absence is stated here as a finding, having been checked against the full text. 2 Ministry of Education parliamentary reply of 13 January 2026, read at source; the quoted phrase is the whole of what was said about results. 3 Parent interviews reported by Mediacorp and republished by the National Institute of Education, 4 Siebers and colleagues, as cited on **p12**. Reddit, KiasuParents and HardwareZone all refused this desk, so no forum sentiment is claimed.

THE MACRO DESK • THE REGIME, IN ONE FACT

Payrolls came in at twenty-nine thousand, the market took an October hike off the table, equities rallied — and the long end sold off anyway

Two independent decompositions, the inflation-protected spread and the Federal Reserve's own term-premium model, say the same thing: this is a real-rate event, not an inflation one.

VWRA 193.84 ▲	AGGU 5.709 ▼	US 10Y 5.311% ▲	DXY 102.12 ▲
USD/SGD 1.2794	BRENT 100.32 ▼	GOLD 4,139.75 ▼	BITCOIN 85,731 ▼

Friday's labour report was soft in every direction. **Twenty-nine thousand** jobs where forecasters had looked for about ninety; unemployment up to **4.2%**, though for the right reason, participation rising to **61.8%**; hourly pay **0.1%** higher on the month and **3.0%** on the year, down from 3.1%. And revisions took **sixty thousand** out of the two prior months — July went from **+21,000** to **-10,000**, an outright contraction. By Monday the market put the odds of an October *hike* — note the direction — below twenty per cent.¹

Equities took the reprieve. The S&P closed at **7,773.95**, within half a per cent of its high; Asia rose about one per cent and the Nikkei two; VWRA added **0.57% to 193.84**. The long end did not. The ten-year rose **3.4 basis points to 5.311%** into the close, and the global aggregate bond proxy fell to **5.709**, three-tenths of a per cent above its fifty-two-week low. **A soft labour print that rallied stocks and still could not rally bonds** is the single most informative fact in the file.²

91%

OF THE TEN-YEAR'S 32-BASIS-POINT RISE FROM 22 SEPTEMBER TO 2 OCTOBER WAS **REAL YIELD** — 2.63% TO 2.92% ON THE INFLATION-PROTECTED SERIES. THE BREAKEVEN MOVED **THREE BASIS POINTS**, AND HAS SAT AT **2.36%** FOR FOUR SESSIONS. *MERIDIAN'S* ARITHMETIC FROM THREE PUBLISHED SERIES³

A second decomposition, on different machinery, agrees. The New York Fed's affine model puts the

ten-year term premium at **0.7715** on 25 September and **0.9137** on 2 October — up **14.2 basis points** against a fitted yield that rose **11.6**. The risk-neutral component, the expected path of short rates, **fell 2.6**. More than the whole move was the price of holding duration; the curve has bear-steepened **25bp in eight sessions**, to **+45**.³

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

The regime: higher-for-longer, dollar-bid, liquidity-tight — and not risk-off. VWRA is being paid for the Fed leg and ignoring the term-premium leg;. **Global bonds** make new lows on a real yield near 2.92% while the breakeven has not moved: holders are losing to duration, not inflation. *Explanation, not advice.*⁴

THE SCEPTIC • "THE DOLLAR IS GOING TO START BREAKING THINGS"

Carley Garner of DeCarley Trading, on 1 October with the dollar index at 102.10: "Do I think gold's going to \$5,000 or \$5,500? No, I don't. But I think the next three or four hundred points is probably on the upside." And then: **"I think the dollar is going to start breaking things."** Her frame cuts against both camps. The risk in this regime is not an inflation scare and not a failed auction; it is that a 102-handle dollar and a near-three-per-cent real yield eventually break something financed assuming neither.⁵

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR BID

REAL-RATE SHOCK

CORRECTIONS AND DATES

Singapore's policy statement is **"not later than 14 October"** — verified again this morning on the central bank's own advance calendar, alongside the Macroeconomic Review. A ceiling, not a date, as No. 123 said.⁶

OPEC+ held November quotas flat at Sunday's meeting, a second straight pause — and Brent fell **1.9% to \$100.32** on Monday anyway. With Hormuz keeping actual output below target (**p3**), the quota is not the binding constraint.⁷

SOURCES 1 United States Bureau of Labor Statistics employment situation release for September, published 2 October, read at source, for the payroll figure, the unemployment and participation rates, earnings and the revisions. The pricing of October odds from a 5 October market note, read at source. 2 Closing levels for 5 October 2026 pulled from the exchange chart interface for each instrument and recorded with their dates; the ten-year is the index print at 18:59 UTC, which is not the afternoon fixing and may differ from it by a basis point. A second note the same day had the ten-year lower on the Asia session before the US market moved. 3 Nominal, inflation-indexed and breakeven ten-year series from the Federal Reserve Bank of St Louis, downloaded as data; the New York Fed's own term-premium spreadsheet, downloaded and parsed locally. The percentage split and the curve arithmetic are *Meridian's*. 4 Levels as above; gold spot and its record from a market data service. **Note:** the two official oil series on the St Louis database disagree with the exchange front-month contracts by eleven to fourteen dollars on the same dates, so the exchange prices are used throughout. 5 Carley Garner quoted by Kitco, 1 October, read at source. 6 Monetary Authority of Singapore advance release calendar, read at source 6 October. 7 OPEC press release of 4 October, read at source.

THE RABBIT HOLE · ROCKHOUNDING AND FOSSIL HUNTING

Two and a half billion *Tyrannosaurus rex* ever lived. About thirty-two good adult skeletons sit in public museums. That ratio is why this hobby's hardest constraint is not the rock but the law

The front door is a subreddit called “what’s this rock”, and it is twenty to thirty times the size of any collectors’ forum. The hobby’s own glossary contains three separate words for a rock not worth keeping.

Rockhounding is the amateur field collection of rocks, minerals and fossils — the finding, not the finishing. Inside the one word sit communities that barely speak: mineral collectors, **micromounters** (a stereo microscope and no hammer at all, the cheapest serious collectors and the most rigorous), fossil hunters, meteorite hunters, prospectors, beachcombers. Fossil people and mineral people do not share a forum.¹

Start with the number that explains everything else. In 2021 a Berkeley team led by Charles Marshall published, in *Science*, an estimate of how many *T. rex* ever existed: a standing population of about **20,000 adults**, a generation of **19 years**, roughly **127,000 generations** across two and a half million years — **about 2.5 billion individuals**. Fewer than a hundred have been found, of which roughly **thirty-two** are relatively well-preserved post-juveniles in public museums. **The preservation-and-discovery rate is about one in eighty million.**²

1 in 80m

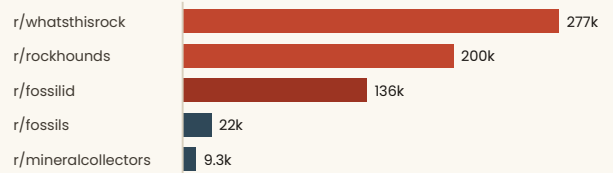
THE SHARE OF ALL *T. REX* THAT EVER LIVED WHICH HAS BEEN FOUND AND PRESERVED. IT IS THE HOBBY’S GOVERNING FACT: DEMAND EXCEEDS SUPPLY BY ORDERS OF MAGNITUDE, WHICH IS WHY THE FAKES EXIST, WHY VERTEBRATES ARE LEGALLY RING-FENCED, AND WHY A SPECIMEN WITHOUT A LOCALITY LABEL HAS THROWN AWAY THE ONLY THING THAT MADE IT RARE²

The gateway is a coastline or a dig site, rarely a club. The hobby’s biggest voice is **Yorkshire Fossils** on YouTube, at **2.85 million subscribers**.³

THE SHAPE OF THE CROWD · THE FRONT DOOR IS IDENTIFICATION

The membership figures tell a story nobody says out loud. Identification subreddits dwarf collecting ones: **r/whatsthisrock** at roughly **277,000** against **r/mineralcollectors** at about **9,300**. Twenty to thirty times as many people want to know what a rock is as want to own a collection.⁴

THE FRONT DOOR IS “WHAT IS THIS ROCK?”



Identification communities (vermillion) against collecting communities (slate). Counts via subredditstats

Meridian original.

Twenty to thirty times as many people want a rock identified as want to collect one. A *Meridian* chart from third-party membership counts; the tracker stopped updating in 2023, so each bar is a floor.

“Leave ’er right here.”

Overleaf, the descent: where specimens come from, and why that tells you where to dig; the gear, running from a thirty-nine-dollar hammer to an ultraviolet lamp at six and a half thousand; the law, which is both the hobby’s hardest limit and the question its forums ask most; and the sceptic’s case, which is a fake industry older than most collectors and a quarrel between palaeontologists that has not been settled.

SOURCES 1 The taxonomy and the micromount definition from the American Federation of Mineralogical Societies’ own Rockhound Glossary, created May 2021 and updated 6 May 2026, read at source as a PDF; the definition quoted is Neal Yedlin’s, as the glossary gives it. 2 Marshall, Latorre, Wilson, Frank, Magoulick, Zimmt and Poust, *Science*, 15 April 2021; figures read in the publisher’s own release, including the 95% interval on the standing population, which runs from 1,300 to 328,000. 3 Subscriber and video counts read from the channels’ own pages on 5 October 2026; the Crater of Diamonds total read on the Arkansas state tourism site, stated as of 13 January 2026. 4 Subreddit memberships from subredditstats.com, read at source, whose banner states its collector stopped working after Reddit’s 2023 interface change. The Fluorescent Mineral Society’s figure and founding dates from its own site. **Refused this desk:** Reddit, Mindat and The Fossil Forum.

THE DEEP END · THE MECHANISM, AND THE KIT

A metre-long crystal does not take a million years. It takes days, and knowing why is what tells a collector where to put the hammer

A granitic pegmatite is the last one or two per cent of a cooling granite magma — the residue holding every element that will not fit a feldspar or quartz lattice: lithium, beryllium, boron, fluorine, caesium, water. Those **fluxes** depress the solidus, so the melt stays liquid far below the temperature at which granite freezes, and collapse its viscosity, so atoms diffuse enormous distances to a growing face. Hence the counterintuitive fact of the craft: **pegmatite bodies reach their solidus in days to months, and metre-scale crystals grow in days to a few years**, not millennia.¹

Which is practical advice, not geology for its own sake. You work the coarse zone and not the granite; you follow the quartz core; you watch for the colour change in the dump; and the **vug** — the void left when the fluid-rich residue outgasses — is what you are after. The logic generalises: veins concentrate metals where fluids cool and lose pressure, placers concentrate heavy minerals where flow slows. Rockhounding is applied thermodynamics, and the good ones know it.¹

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY WILL CERTIFY ANY OF IT

The fake-trilobite industry is older than most collectors. A French dealer publishes a detection guide against his own interest and traces it to the nineteenth century: Barrande's "stone men" near Prague, paid more for better finds, began manufacturing them, and "many of these tricked trilobites have even found their way into the collections of major European museums" — one assembled from a *Phacops* head, an *Odontochile* tail and four segments of thorax. **The tells:** resin bubbles under half a millimetre, a colour break between resin and host rock, and no crack line — genuine Devonian Moroccan rock splits across the matrix. There is no authentication body at retail for either.²

Now the gear, and it is a two-decade ladder with one brand at the bottom of it. The **Estwing** rock pick is the default, and its codes confuse everyone: the **E3-22P** and the **E3-23LP** differ only in handle length, **13 against 16 inches**, both 22 ounces, both the moulded vinyl grip. The leather model is the **E30**, and it is 13 inches — **there is no long-handled leather pick in the current line**. Since both are forged in one piece from the same steel, this is a grip argument and not a tool argument, whatever anyone tells you.³

WHY A BRICKLAYER'S HAMMER IS WRONG · FROM THE MAKER'S OWN SAFETY PAGE

Estwing publishes the answer and almost nobody reads it. "Bricklayer Hammers are used for setting or splitting bricks." And: **"Never strike a hammer or any striking tool against another tool or hardened object."** Strike a chisel and the striking face should be about three-eighths of an inch wider than the struck one. Discard any hammer with a mushroomed face. The page cites the occupational and mine-safety eye rules by number, and the clinical literature backs it: one series found **38.5% of workplace eye injuries happened while hammering**, ahead of chemicals at 23%, and in another **95.2% of injured workers wore no eye protection**. Safety glasses cost **\$5.85**: the cheapest insurance in the hobby.⁴

130×

THE SPAN OF THE ULTRAVIOLET LADDER, AND THE HOBBY'S SHARPEST BUY-ONCE DECISION. A 365NM LONGWAVE TORCH IS **\$49.95**; THE CLASSIC FRANKLIN RESPONSE — WILLEMITE GREEN, CALCITE RED — IS A **SHORTWAVE** RESPONSE, AND A 254NM BENCH LAMP IS **\$6,595**⁵

SOURCES 1 The pegmatite mechanism follows David London's constitutional zone-refining account as summarised in the pegmatite literature; this desk could not open the primary papers, whose host returned errors, so the temperature and timescale figures are attributed to that body of work rather than quoted from it, and the practical consequences are standard field geology. 2 Le Comptoir Géologique's fake-trilobite guide, read at source, which cites Budik and Turek (2003), Šnajdr (1992) and Burkhard and Bode (2003) for the historical and Moroccan material; quotations are as that page gives them. The American Museum of Natural History maintains its own fake-trilobite page, which refused this desk and is therefore cited and not quoted. 3 Model specifications read on Estwing's own site, 3 Model specifications read on Estwing's own site, 5 October 2026; prices at Tiger Supplies, Kingsley North and Shannon's Minerals the same day. **Correcting a common recommendation:** neither Gränsfors Bruk nor Hultafors makes a geological hammer. 4 Estwing's safety and product-care page, read at source and quoted verbatim, including its citations to the occupational and mine-safety eye-protection rules; the injury proportions are aggregated from several clinical papers surfaced in search and not read individually. 5 Lamp prices read at Kingsley North, Mineralab, UV Tools and UV Systems on 5 October 2026.

THE DEEP END • THE LAW, AND THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Twenty-five pounds a day, non-powered hand tools, negligible disturbance — and never a vertebrate. The American rule is written down, and it is the answer to the question the forums ask most

The operative text is **43 CFR § 49.810**, the regulation implementing the Paleontological Resources Preservation Act of 2009, in force since August 2022. “**Casual collecting**” means collecting without a permit “a reasonable amount of common invertebrate or plant paleontological resources for non-commercial personal use, either by surface collection or the use of non-powered hand tools, resulting in only negligible disturbance.” A reasonable amount is **25 pounds a day per person** — with one sensible exception, that you may remove a heavier slab if that is what it takes to keep an embedded specimen intact.¹

The land agency’s own guide puts the rest plainly. Rocks, mineral specimens, common invertebrate fossils and semiprecious gemstones: yes, in reasonable amounts, non-commercially. **Vertebrate fossils: never, without a permit** — “only researchers operating under a BLM permit” may take dinosaurs, mammals, fish and reptiles, and what they take “remains public property.” Common invertebrates “may not be bartered or sold.” Petrified wood has its own arithmetic: **25 pounds plus one piece a day, 250 pounds a year**. Arrowheads are off limits. Modern money may be collected; historic coins may not.²

3 words

IN THE HOBBY’S OWN GLOSSARY FOR A ROCK NOT WORTH KEEPING: **LEAVERITE** (SAY IT ALOUD), **TRASH ROCK**, AND **JUST A ROCK**. AN INSTITUTION THAT HAS STANDARDISED THREE TERMS FOR DISAPPOINTMENT IS BEING HONEST WITH ITS NEWCOMERS³

SOURCES 1 Title 43 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Part 49, section 810, read at source through Cornell’s Legal Information Institute; the Act dates from 30 March 2009 and the regulation from 2 August 2022, and the definitions are quoted verbatim. 2 The Bureau of Land Management’s own public guide, “Can I Keep This? A guide to collecting on public lands”, 2021 revision, read at source as a PDF and quoted verbatim throughout. **This is American law only.** Britain’s position differs materially — the Jurassic Coast and Scottish collecting codes turn on landowner permission and on not digging *in situ* in a cliff face — and this desk could not open the Scottish code to quote it. 3 The American Federation of Mineralogical Societies’ Rockhound Glossary, read at source; the three dismissive terms are quoted from it. 4 The Society of Vertebrate Paleontology’s letter to editors of 21 April 2020, read at source and quoted verbatim; the counter-case from “Burmese Amber Fossils: Mining, Sales and Profits”, *Geoconservation Research* 3(1), June 2020, also read at source and quoted verbatim. 5 Prices as footnoted on **p16**, plus Kingsley North’s loupe and screening-pan listings. The beginner guidance is quoted from rockhounding.org’s gear guide of March 2026 — **noting** that the same organisation sells an identification app and a membership bundling it, which it does not disclose. 6 Both operators’ own pages, read at source and quoted as written.

THE SCEPTIC • THE FIGHT THAT IS STILL LIVE

The Society of Vertebrate Paleontology, writing to journal editors in April 2020 for “over 2,000 researchers”, holds that privately owned fossils “cannot be regarded as reliably available for study, cannot be considered part of reproducible science, and must not be introduced in scientific literature” — a rule covering even specimens on long-term museum loan. The same letter asks for a **moratorium on publishing Burmese amber bought after June 2017**, when the military moved on the mines. **The counter-case is peer-reviewed.** A 2020 paper in *Geoconservation Research* finds that at the 2016 peak some **200,000 to 300,000 people** were digging and trading amber in the Hukawng Valley, that the armed group taxed it at 30% while miners “never paid direct taxes to the Myanmar government until 2016”, and that its authors “could find no definitive evidence... of amber profits going to the Myanmar government or military during the peak mining period”. Both stand. A collector buying an inclusion at a show this year is buying into a live dispute.⁴

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, AT REAL PRICES

Spend under a hundred dollars and lurk first. A hammer (**\$39–\$43**), safety glasses (**\$5.85**), a 10× Hastings triplet loupe (**\$14.95**) and a stacked screen set (three pans at **\$16.10**) is the whole kit.⁵

Then find a legal place to stand. That is the real first task, and it is the regional federations and the local club — not a map found online — that supply it, along with access to dumps and claims a newcomer cannot reach alone.³

And read the honest pay-to-dig pages. One North Carolina site states in capitals that its buckets are **filled with native soil and not sifted beforehand**; a New York operator says there are “guaranteed finds in ALL bags” and that only one contains the local quartz — a plain admission that the other three are salted. The sites that disclose are the ones to use.⁶

NEXT DESCENTS

Bookbinding & book repair — Coptic to case binding, bone folders and linen thread, and an archival-materials rabbit hole underneath.

Ham-free satellite tracking & SatNOGS — a receive-only space hobby with a real open-hardware ground-station ladder.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and a cave in the spare fridge; the one craft whose failure modes are edible.

FITNESS · THE MAINTENANCE DOSE, ANSWERED

Four weeks of wall squats took nine and a half points off systolic pressure. A new trial asked how little you can then do to keep it, and the answer is: almost all of it

And a second paper, from a different university, put a blood-pressure cuff on people doing the same exercise and had to stop ninety-seven per cent of them inside a minute.

The trial, published on **29 September** in *BMJ Open Sport & Exercise Medicine* by the Canterbury group that has driven this literature, randomised **100 adults** with normal to high-normal pressure, mean age **37**, 45% women, baseline systolic 128 to 132. Everyone did the same four weeks first: **isometric wall squats, thrice weekly — four bouts, two seated minutes between them, at 95% of peak heart rate, at home.**¹

After four weeks, against control: systolic **-9.45 ± 6.69 mmHg**, diastolic **-5.47 ± 9.92**, mean arterial pressure **-6.80 ± 7.77**. They were then randomised again — three, two, one or none a week — for four more. At week eight: **three a week, 117.47; two, 122.49; one, 123.33; none, 127.66** — against a control group at 128.59. **This is not an investment. It is a subscription.**¹

97%

OF HEALTHY YOUNG ADULTS DOING A PLANK, AND **98%** DOING A WALL SIT, HAD TO BE STOPPED FOR EXCEEDING THE DIASTOLIC SAFETY CEILING OF 115 MMHG — AFTER ABOUT **FIFTY SECONDS**. AMONG THE WOMEN, **100%** ON BOTH EXERCISES²

THE SCEPTIC · THE NUMBER THE ENTHUSIASM LEAVES OUT

A team at the University of New South Wales, with the hypertension researcher **Aletta Schutte** among the authors, put continuous beat-to-beat monitoring on **62 healthy adults**, mean age 26.7, resting 121 over 77, and had them hold the two exercises the longevity internet recommends. Their conclusion: “Common isometric exercises cause a marked increase in BP, particularly DBP... Future studies should examine the dose-response... in **higher risk populations**.” Set that against a prescription of four bouts at ninety-five per cent of peak heart rate, and the honest statement is that the chronic benefit is well measured and the acute pressor response in people who are not twenty-six has not been.²

THE CHATTER · THE LONGEVITY WORLD, AND A USEFUL FRAME

Peter Attia, with Lauren Fritsch and Michael Rae on 26 September, offers the frame: “We have finite time, attention, money, and effort, so interventions are effectively competing with one another for those resources.” And: “Capture the large effect first, then worry about the smaller increments.” His hierarchy puts lipids, blood pressure, exercise, sleep and nutrition ahead of peptides and red light, and names the optimisation trap of “perfecting an already-good program rather than maintaining consistency with a reasonable one.” A nine-and-a-half-point systolic reduction is a large effect. Reddit’s fitness forums refused this desk.³

THE HONEST LIMITS, PRINTED

The mean age was 37, not 47. Reading this across to a mid-forties reader is an extrapolation, and the trial says so by saying nothing about it.¹

And it is not a strength programme. The careful review of the isometric literature finds it a supplemental tool for sticking points and rehabilitation — comparable isokinetic strength gains, hypertrophy better at longer muscle lengths — not a replacement for dynamic compound work. For a reader who already has a trainer, this is an addition, and a small one.⁴

General guidance, not medical advice. Isometric work raises diastolic pressure sharply in nearly everyone who does it. Anyone with diagnosed or suspected hypertension, cardiovascular disease, or on blood-pressure medication should speak to a doctor before attempting a protocol pitched at ninety-five per cent of peak heart rate.

SOURCES 1 Swift, Pedlar, Coleman, Buckley and Wiles, “Isometric exercise training and blood pressure control: exploring the dose-response to training frequency in a randomised controlled trial”, *BMJ Open Sport & Exercise Medicine*, published 29 September 2026; abstract and open-access full text both read at source, for the design, the protocol, every pressure figure, the adherence counts, the declared absence of funding and the limitation quoted verbatim. 2 Jones, Tan, Woo, Bui, Wong, Fotheringham, Schutte and Parmenter, “Acute blood pressure responses to plank and wall sit isometric exercise in adults”, *Journal of Hypertension*, 2 Jones, Tan, Woo, Bui, Wong, Fotheringham, Schutte and Parmenter, *Journal of Hypertension*, 14 November 2025, University of New South Wales; abstract read at source for the sample, the stopping proportions with their intervals, the fifty-second mean and the conclusion quoted verbatim. 3 Attia, Fritsch and Rae, 26 September 2026, read at source and quoted verbatim; Reddit returned 403. 4 Varović’s review of the isometric literature, read at source and dated April 2026, printed as context rather than news.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

Three of the biggest things on this page cannot be bought. The sumo tournament worth flying for is sold out for all fifteen days — and this year there is no same-day queue either

Each entry here was put back to a promoter, a venue or an official seller this morning. Where the ticketing sites refused us, we say so rather than repeat a listing.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

10
OCT–
8
NOV

★ Deepavali — Little India Festival Village

CAMPBELL LANE, NIGHTLY FROM 7PM; THE STREET LIGHT-UP RUNS 7PM TO MIDNIGHT OVER ABOUT 2KM OF SERANGOON ROAD. **FREE**. THE HELD THREAD CLOSES: **DEEPAVALI IS SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER**, WITH MONDAY THE 9TH IN LIEU — NOT THE 7TH THAT SEVERAL LISTINGS CARRY¹

1–30
OCT

★ Popaholic — Esplanade

RUNNING NOW, LISTED BY THE VENUE UNDER **FREE PROGRAMMES**. THE WALK-IN, ALL-AGES ITEM OF THE WEEK²

13–22
NOV

★ Singapore Writers Festival — “Hidden in Plain Sight”

VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE AND THE NATIONAL GALLERY · **FESTIVAL PASS \$30, EARLY BIRD \$24; YOUTH PASS \$15, EARLY BIRD \$12**, EACH COVERING 100+ PROGRAMMES · 29TH EDITION, AND ITS DIRECTOR'S LAST²

4–6
DEC

★ Singapore International Marathon

RENAMED THIS CYCLE — SEARCH THE OLD TITLE AND YOU LAND ON LAST YEAR. **REGISTRATION FOR THE 10KM, 5KM AND KIDS DASH EXTENDED TO 31 OCTOBER**; MARATHON INTERNATIONAL SLOTS **SOLD OUT**. THE FAMILY PICK, AND THE MOST ACTIONABLE DATE ON THIS PAGE³

17, 19,
20
& 22
DEC

★ BTS — 〈Arirang〉, four nights

NATIONAL STADIUM, 7PM · THE PROMOTER'S OWN PAGE STILL SHOWS THE GRID — **\$148 TO \$388** — AND MARKS BOTH THE GENERAL AND PARTNER SALES **SOLD OUT**, WITH NO BREAKDOWN BY NIGHT. A DIARY ENTRY, NOT A RECOMMENDATION⁴

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

8–22
NOV

★ Grand Sumo — the Kyushu Basho

FUKUOKA. THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN ENGLISH SITE AND ITS OFFICIAL TICKET AGENT BOTH READ: **“TICKETS ARE SOLD OUT ALL DATES. THERE WILL BE NO TICKETS SOLD ON THE DAY.”** KYUSHU IS THE BASHO THAT NORMALLY REWARDS TURNING UP EARLY WITH CASH. THE GENERAL SALE OPENED 19 SEPTEMBER AND CLEARED⁵

31
OCT–
28
MAR

★ Mariko Mori — All That Shines

MORI ART MUSEUM, 53RD FLOOR, ROPPONGI HILLS · 10AM–10PM, TO 5PM TUESDAYS · **¥2,800 WEEKDAY, ¥3,000 WEEKEND; JUNIOR HIGH AND UNDER FREE** · HER FIRST SHOW IN JAPAN SINCE 2002. **BOOK THE WAVE UFO POD WITH THE TICKET** — ITS SLOTS ARE LIMITED AND SEPARATE⁶

28
NOV

★ Niseko United opens

ALL FOUR MOUNTAINS OPEN 28 NOVEMBER AND **CLOSE ON THREE DIFFERENT DATES** — NISEKO VILLAGE 4 APRIL, HANAZONO 11 APRIL, ANNUPURI AND GRAND HIRAFU 5 MAY. NIGHT SKIING 12 DEC–22 MAR. PEAK ALL-MOUNTAIN ADULT DAY PASS **¥13,500**⁷

4–11
FEB

★ Sapporo Snow Festival, 77th

CONFIRMED ON THE CITY'S OWN TOURISM SITE: ODORI PARK OVER 1.5KM, SUSUKINO FOR ICE, AND **TSUDOME** FOR THE SLIDES — WHICH IS THE TWELVE-YEAR-OLD'S SITE. ODORI IS BEAUTIFUL AND IS ALSO AN HOUR OF STANDING IN THE COLD⁸

9–11
APR

★ Hong Kong Sevens 2027 — Kai Tak Stadium

DATES CONFIRMED; THE SITE READS **“TICKETING DETAILS TO FOLLOW”**. SEVENS SEATS GO BY BALLOT AND THE BALLOT IS NOT OPEN: REGISTER INTEREST NOW, BOOK FLIGHTS LATER⁹

PLANNING NOTES · WHAT HAS ALREADY GONE, AND WHAT HAS NOT

There is no “sold out in four minutes” figure this week, and the honest equivalent is structural. The **2027 Singapore Grand Prix is a waitlist-only product a full year out** — the official ticketing page offers no categories and no prices, including a separate waitlist for general admission. When a race sells its cheapest tier by queue, that is the fact. And the aggregator trap, three times over: **Christmas Wonderland's dates, Orchard Road's light-up and ZoukOut's entire line-up** are circulating, and in all three the organiser's own site either still shows last year or does not mention the event.¹⁰

SOURCES 1 The public-holiday date read on the Ministry of Manpower's own page; the light-up and Festival Village dates from local coverage, the organiser's own pages being unreachable, and flagged accordingly. 2 Esplanade's festival pages, the Singapore Writers Festival site, Singapore Repertory Theatre's show and season pages and artweek.sg, each read at source on 6 October for dates, venues and the full price grids. 3 The race's own site, read at source, for the window, the extended registration deadline and the sold-out international allocation; entry fees sit behind a link that did not render and are not printed. 4 Live Nation Singapore's own event page, read at source, for the four dates, the price grid and the sold-out status. 5 The Japan Sumo Association's English site and its official ticket agent, both read at source and both carrying the quoted sentences. 6 Mori Art Museum's own exhibition page, for dates, hours, every price tier and the pod note. 7 Niseko United's own lift pages. 8 The City of Sapporo's tourism site; admission is not stated there, so “free” is not printed. 9 hksevns.com. 10 Checked against christmaswonderland.sg, the Orchard Road Christmas site and Zouk Group's own events calendar, each failing to support the circulating listing. **Refused this desk:** Marina Bay Sands on every route, SISTIC, Ticketmaster Singapore and the Sports Hub.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

Our own ledger barred three of this month's five "new" restaurants, because we had already run them. Two more on the same roundups opened in May 2025 and May 2026

The Table's problem this week is not finding openings. It is that the lists recycling them have no memory, and neither did we until we built one.

Start with the one that is dated, priced and genuinely new. **Molly Tea**, the Shenzhen tea brand, opens its third Singapore outlet at **Hillion Mall, #B1-42/43**, 17 Petir Road, on **9 October** — its first west of the centre, by Bukit Panjang station, **\$5.20 to \$6.50**, daily 10am to 10pm.¹

Shared Table, at 1382 Ang Mo Kio Avenue 1 inside Bishan-Ang Mo Kio Park, is the opposite proposition: a parkside, pet-friendly cafe built on the Japanese *ichiju sansai* principle of one soup and three dishes, with a Nourish Plate from **\$21.90**. Two outlets have written it up and neither has reviewed it — the language is about the room, "bright and airy by day", not the cooking. **Too new to judge**.²

And **Um Yong Baek**, the Busan *gukbap* specialist, is opening a **third Singapore outlet at Suntec City** with a new beef bone broth. The restaurant announced it through an Instagram story on **30 September** and says this month; the exact date is still unconfirmed, which is why it is a line here and not a pick. The broth is the peg — a third outlet on its own would not be one.³

THE BUZZ · THE VERDICT RUN THAT FOUND NO VERDICT

Les Canons carried this strip at its opening in No. 110, as the iLido group's Parisian bistro in the IOI Central Boulevard lobby. Fourteen issues later, the return visit finds the thing it promised intact and the thing it needs still missing. Its own site holds the format: **walk-ins only, no reservations at all**; Monday to Friday breakfast from 8.30, all-day dining 11am to 10pm; Saturday 11 to 10; closed Sunday. The price architecture is the news — **everything under \$22**, wine by the glass from \$8, happy hour from \$6. What there still is not, six weeks on, is a review of substance from anyone. The one outlet with an assessment calls it an accessible neighbourhood spot for weekday lunches and after-work drinks, which is a description. **The question nobody has asked in print: whether a sub-\$22 ceiling holds on portion and quality once the opening crowd thins**.⁴

WALK-INS ONLY

UNDER \$22

BUKIT PANJANG

TOO NEW TO JUDGE

THE SCEPTIC · THE LISTS HAVE NO MEMORY

This is the honesty ledger, and it is about us as much as them. Of the five restaurants this desk's research surfaced as October openings, **three were barred by our own Table ledger because we had already run them** — five, six and three issues ago. Of the two that survived, one is a chain's third outlet and one has no reviews. No. 123 killed four "new openings" on their dates and No. 121 four more; the roundups corrected none. **A restaurant is not new because a listicle is**. Before the ledger existed, one place ran four times in thirteen issues and another was named in eighteen.⁵

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Suntec date for the *gukbap* house — announced by Instagram story and still not fixed. Held until a date is published.³

And one booking fact worth more than a review: the bistro above takes **no reservations of any kind**. In a lunch-crush location that is a deliberate bet on turnover. Go at 11.30 or after two, and skip the half-twelve scrum entirely.⁴

SOURCES 1 Eatbook's October listing, read at source, for the opening date, the unit number, the price range and the hours. 2 Sassy Mama and The Ranting Panda, both read at source, for the address, the concept and the plate price; neither carries an assessment of the food, which is why this entry says so. 3 redhot.sg, reporting the restaurant's own Instagram announcement of 30 September; no date has been published and none is printed. 4 lesanons.sg, the venue's own site, read at source on 6 October for the hours, the closed day and the walk-ins-only policy; the price architecture from Sassy Mama, read at source. The venue last appeared in this strip in No. 110. 5 lesanons.sg, the venue's own site, read at source on 6 October for the hours, the closed day and the walk-ins-only policy; the price architecture from Sassy Mama. The venue last appeared in this strip in No. 110. 6 This desk's own Table ledger, which bars a second run inside seven issues and any run after two; the three barred this week ran in Nos. 119, 118 and 121. 6 Reddit refused every route, so no social chatter is claimed; SETHLUI returned 403. Every "too new to judge" means exactly that.

THE UNDERCURRENT · VANUATU

A country has made its daily social institution into its principal export, and discovered that the export market outbids the institution

Kava is 68.5% of what Vanuatu sells abroad. The price of the root has roughly tripled since January 2025, which is excellent news for twenty-seven thousand farming households — and the reason the cheapest shell in Port Vila has disappeared and the lamps are going off in Luganville.

The word is **nakamal**. In Bislama it now means a kava bar, but it did not start there: the root is Proto-Oceanic, parsed as the article *na* plus *kamal*, and it meant the **men's house** — the structure where a chief held authority, where disputes were settled, where the village argued itself into agreement after dark. In Port Vila the meaning slid sideways into commerce without quite letting go of the first sense. It also sells you a shell of kava at a price, and the price is the subject of this essay.¹

Begin with what makes Vanuatu's case unusual. The standard commodity story is extraction: the valuable thing leaves, the place stays poor. Not here. Kava is not a plantation crop and, by a 2019 policy, cannot be foreign-owned. It is grown by roughly **27,000 households** across the northern islands, and the boom is making them better off exactly as the textbook promises.²

3.4×

THE RISE IN THE FARMGATE PRICE OF GREEN KAVA SINCE THE BASE HELD FROM 2019 TO JANUARY 2025 — VT500 A KILOGRAM TO ABOUT VT1,700. MERIDIAN'S ARITHMETIC FROM THE TWO PUBLISHED PRICES²

On Santo a grower named **Harrykon Tom** sells 50 kilograms a week or more at municipal rates that pay by the age of the plant — **VT700 for two to three years, VT800 for four, VT1,000 for five and over**. That price ladder is a market mechanism working correctly: it pays people to leave the root in the ground. He will tell you what the money was for. “The first goal I planted kava for was to build a nice house and a toilet and bathroom.” Nothing in this essay argues he should have been paid less.³

What is being destroyed is at the other end of the same pipe. The shell — the half coconut you drink from — is the unit in which ordinary ni-Vanuatu experience the price of kava, and it has been climbing through a fixed ladder of denominations that everyone in Port Vila knows by heart. By midsummer the reporting was blunt: **“some kava bars are no longer accepting VT50 per shell... prices now start at VT100, VT200 and VT300, while VT50, VT150 and VT250 shells are no longer available at some kava bars.”** The cheapest drink in the country stopped existing. That is how a price shock is actually felt — not as a statistic but as the disappearance of a rung.⁴

“Thousands of people in Port Vila and Luganville earn money every day from kava, not from passports.”

And then the lamps. A hurricane lamp outside a nakamal is its open sign, and in Luganville some well-known bars have begun switching off their coloured lights and closing on certain nights. The mothers who sold VT20 snacks at the door have lost that income with them. Theft has entered the conversation, which in Vanuatu is a significant social signal: a bar owner in Simbolo went to the police over five kilograms taken in daylight. **Sylverio Molkis**, of the Beverly Hills quarter, states the mechanism without ornament: “The price of green kava is now VT1,500 in Port Vila... The high price will encourage stealing.”⁵

SOURCES 1 The etymology of *nakamal* from the standard reference account, which traces it to Proto-Oceanic by way of the article *na*; this desk did not open a Bislama dictionary, and the gloss is printed as a derivation rather than a lexicographic finding. 2 Price series assembled from the Vanuatu Business Review's own reporting of 4 August 2025, 5 January 2026, 9 June 2026 and 22 June 2026, and its September report of the Namburu market, each read at source; the multiple is this desk's division of the two published figures. The 2019 ownership policy as reported in the same stable. 3 The Santo age-banded rates and the quotation from the Vanuatu Business Review's profile of the grower, read at source. 4 The Santo age-banded rates and the quotation from the Vanuatu Business Review's profile of the grower. 5 The Luganville closures reached this desk as a search summary of a report whose body it could read only in part, and are attributed as reported; the Simbolo theft and the quotation are from the 22 June report, read at source.

The mechanism that connects the farmer's good fortune to the drinker's bad one runs through four joints, and each is worth naming. The first is geography: **Port Vila grows essentially no kava.** Every shell drunk in the capital arrived by ship or plane from the northern islands. The second is the choice the grower now faces. He can sell green root locally, or he can dry it and sell into the export channel, where **dried kava fetches VT4,600 a kilogram in South Pentecost** and farmers expect five thousand. Drying it and selling it abroad beats carting wet root to the capital.¹

The third joint is freight, and it is the real engine. By sea, a shipping line charges **VT10,000 for a large "parachute bag"** of roughly 200 to 300 kilograms, on two voyages a month. By air, when the ship is too slow or a bar has run dry, one operator charters at **VT499,000 to Maewo and VT300,000 to Santo**, carrying five to six hundred kilograms. Do the division: **about VT33 to VT50 a kilo by sea, and VT500 to VT1,000 by air** — a factor of ten to thirty. The air option exists at all because urban demand has become inelastic enough to pay for it, which is itself the clearest evidence that the nakamal has turned from a commons into a business.²

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THE RATIO OF AIR FREIGHT TO SEA FREIGHT FOR A KILOGRAM OF KAVA BETWEEN THE ISLANDS AND THE CAPITAL, AT THE MIDPOINTS OF BOTH RANGES — ROUGHLY VT600 AGAINST VT40. MERIDIAN'S ARITHMETIC FROM THE CARRIERS' OWN PUBLISHED RATES²

The fourth joint is labour, and it arrives from an unexpected direction. The men who would dig the roots are in New Zealand and Australia on seasonal schemes. One Port Vila nakamal owner employs around fifty-one people and describes them as "mostly part-time... farmers and families who work seasonally before departing" for those programmes. A former agriculture minister, **Matai Seremaiah**, put it to a forum plainly: "If we continue to export labour overseas, it will bring another great challenge for kava production by local farmers." With fewer hands and a tripled price, plants are being pulled early. **Dr Vincent Lebot** of the French agricultural research centre CIRAD, the leading scientist in this crop, says

so in public: "Many plants are being harvested too early, less than three years old, which goes against the Kava Act of 2002."³

And an immature plant is a wet one. Up to **half of a parachute bag** can be lost to rot, because young roots carry high moisture and low dry matter; a Port Vila bar turns a hundred kilograms of fresh kava into fifty of usable product. So the boom is simultaneously raising the price, shortening the crop cycle, degrading the product and destroying a portion of it in transit — four effects of one cause.⁴

THE COUNTER-CASE · AND IT IS STRONG

The official position is that the shortage is unproven. The Director of Agriculture says the department is prioritising replanting but that **"this shortage needs to be verified due to no up-to-date statistics"**, and the minister's own framing is a data complaint. The sharper dissent comes from a man with every commercial reason to cry shortage. **Chief Theodore**, president of the Port Vila Council of Chiefs and owner of the Anamburu kava market, says the opposite of what his interests would suggest: "It's not because farmers don't have kava... There is kava in the islands, but the roads make it too hard for farmers to harvest." On his reading there is no collision between export and nakamal at all — there is a feeder-road deficit. Note also who benefits from each diagnosis. Exporters use the shortage to argue for relaxing the local-ownership rule; town bar owners use it to lobby for a transport subsidy and an agreed shell price; chiefs use it to ask for a factory, mechanisation and an eleven-kilometre road. **Everyone's explanation implies their own budget line.**⁵

WHAT IS NOT KNOWN, AND SHOULD BE

Three figures circulate for the 2024 export value — **VT3,171m, VT5.3bn and "over VT6 billion"** — and nobody has reconciled them in print. No full-year 2025 figure appears to exist publicly. Nobody publishes a green-to-dried conversion ratio, so the domestic and export markets cannot be compared at all. Freight is quoted at VT10,000 a bag by the carrier and about VT40,000 by a farmer in the same month, unexplained. The national quality standard is, by the account of the programme that built it, **voluntary**. And there is **no count of nakamals** — not nationally, not for Port Vila. For a country where this is the central social institution, that absence is itself a finding.⁶

SOURCES 1 That the capital grows no kava, and the dried-kava prices, from the Vanuatu Business Review's reporting of 9 June 2026 and its earlier pieces on the capital's supply, read at source. 2 Sea freight from the shipping line's national operations manager, quoted in the Vanuatu Business Review of 24 August 2026; the charter figures from the same stable's profile of the nakamal owner. Both per-kilogram ranges and the ratio are *Meridian's* arithmetic from those published rates and payload figures. 3 The employment description from that profile; Seremaiah quoted in the Vanuatu Business Review, 28 November 2024; Lebot quoted in the Vanuatu Daily Post, 19 July 2025. All read at source. 3 The employment description from that profile; Seremaiah quoted in the Vanuatu Business Review, 28 November 2024; Lebot in the Vanuatu Daily Post, 19 July 2025. 4 Post-harvest loss figures and Lebot's quotation from the Daily Post's report of the October 2025 kava forum. **Held:** the Kava Act 2002 could not be opened — the legal database returned 403 — so its three-year provision is reported as Lebot characterises it. 5 The Director of Agriculture's remark reached this desk in a search summary and is attributed as reported; Chief Theodore's quotations from the Daily Post of 5 January 2026. His surname is given two ways in the same newspaper and is therefore not printed. 6 The three export figures as published by the Vanuatu Business Review, the Vanuatu Daily Post and a chief quoted in the former.

There is a precedent, exact enough to be uncomfortable. Between 2015 and 2019 a smallholder crop on a poor island economy met a demand shock from Western consumers: Madagascar’s vanilla, as food manufacturers moved from synthetic vanillin to the natural bean. Prices went from about **US\$84 a kilogram at the start of 2015 to US\$205 by January 2016** and on toward six and seven hundred — far beyond the shortfall in supply, which observers called speculative. Three things followed, in order: theft from plantations; **premature harvesting**, growers pulling pods early and vacuum-packing them green rather than curing them; and a collapse in quality that pushed industrial buyers back toward substitutes and set up the bust.¹

Vanuatu’s parachute bag of immature, high-moisture root, half of it rotten on arrival, is Madagascar’s green vacuum-packed pod. The difference — and it is the whole point of this essay — is that **Madagascar’s vanilla was never drunk in Madagascar**. Nobody in Antalaha lost the room.

“Now with the high price, there is no quality control... could lead to another ban.”

That sentence is the one to end on, and it belongs to **Chief Graim Tevimeme**, who chairs the Pentecost Island Council of Chiefs. He is not speculating about an abstraction. Vanuatu has been destroyed once already by a foreign regulator’s verdict on quality: in **June 2002** Germany’s drug agency banned kava extracts over reported liver injury, and France, Britain, Japan, Australia, Canada, Switzerland and Singapore followed. European kava sales had been running at roughly **€100 million a year**, about half of it German. The demand side of this market has vanished on a signature before.²

So what is the argument? Not that the boom is bad. The distributional case runs squarely against the urban drinker: twenty-seven thousand households are getting the best terms of trade in living memory, and a story about a bar closing is also a story about a bathroom being built. The argument is narrower and stranger than that. It is that a small economy with

one tradeable discovers, when the world’s terms of trade turn generous, that **its civic infrastructure is for sale at the margin** — one shell at a time — and that it has almost no instrument to hold any of it back. Vanuatu’s entire state effort against this runs to a **kava development budget of VT10 million a year**, against **VT5.3 billion** of exports and a domestic market several times larger. That is roughly **one and nine-tenths vatu of public money for every thousand vatu exported**.³

VT10m

THE ANNUAL NATIONAL KAVA DEVELOPMENT BUDGET, AGAINST **VT5,300M** OF EXPORTS IN 2024 — **0.19%**. THE REPLANTING PROGRAMME IT FUNDS DISTRIBUTED ABOUT **600,000** PLANTS IN FIVE YEARS AGAINST A TARGET OF **TEN MILLION BY 2030**. MERIDIAN’S ARITHMETIC³

Note also who the second-order losers are, because the pattern generalises past the Pacific. Not the farmer, who got the price. Not the exporter, who has a waiting list and turns customers away. It is the VT50 drinker, the woman selling VT20 snacks at the door, and the Luganville bar that switched off its lamp — the people furthest from the money and closest to the institution. A country can run a successful export industry and lose the room it used to argue in, and the national accounts will record only the first half.

The thing to watch, then, is not the price. It is the first rejected container. The chiefs are saying in public that the conditions for a repeat of 2002 are being manufactured by the boom itself; the standard that would prevent it is voluntary; the Act that would prevent it is, by the leading scientist’s account, routinely broken; and the department that enforces it issued an unexplained reminder to exporters on **3 August** and would not tell the newspaper that asked what had prompted it. Meanwhile the quarterly numbers have already turned: in the second quarter of this year **Vanuatu’s shipments to Australia fell 29.2% while Fiji’s rose 51.7%**, and Fiji recorded its strongest quarter on record. Vanuatu has thirty registered suppliers to that market; Fiji has two hundred and twenty of them. **A grower from South Pentecost, Donald Wabak, gave the whole argument a sentence: thousands of people earn money every day from kava, not from passports**.⁴

SOURCES 1 The Madagascar vanilla figures — the 2015 and 2016 prices and the sequence of theft, premature harvest and quality collapse — reached this desk through secondary coverage of the period rather than a primary trade series, and are printed as a characterised precedent rather than as a verified price history. 2 Tevimeme quoted in the Vanuatu Business Review, read at source. The 2002 German ban, the European market size, the four-of-seventy-six re-evaluation and the 2024 court decision are reported in the clinical and trade literature; this desk read them in secondary summary and flags them as such, while noting that Singapore’s own 2002 recall is a matter of local record. 3 The VT10m annual budget and the VT5.3bn 2024 export figure as presented by the Director of Agriculture at the October 2025 kava forum and read at source; the percentage and the per-thousand figure are Meridian’s arithmetic. 4 Quarterly Australian import volumes from Pacific Trade Invest Australia’s second-quarter 2026 summary of the trade department’s own data, downloaded and read in full, including the supplier counts. Biosecurity’s August reminder and the unanswered question from the Vanuatu Business Review. Wabak quoted in the same stable.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

The cheapest rung

A shell of kava in Port Vila used to cost twenty vatu, then fifty. This year the fifty-vatu shell stopped existing. The rungs now begin at a hundred and climb through two hundred to three hundred, and a bar in Luganville switched off its coloured lights on some nights because there was nothing to sell. Nobody decided this. Twenty-seven thousand farming households were simply offered a better price by somebody further away.

It is worth noticing what kind of loss that is, because it does not appear anywhere. Vanuatu's export earnings are up. Its farmgate prices are up. A grower on Santo built a house and a bathroom with the difference, and said so. Every number a country collects about itself says this is going well, and every number is right. What is not collected is the count of nakamals, which does not exist — not nationally, not for the capital — in a country where the nakamal is where disputes are settled and the news is heard.

There is a version of this in almost every desk of a magazine like this one. What is measured gets managed; what is not measured gets spent, quietly, at the margin, by people acting entirely reasonably. The honest thing a newspaper can do about that is print the absence: say that the figure does not exist, say who it would have counted, and resist the temptation to estimate it.

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A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the environment agency's own real-time air-quality feed at five this morning (p5); the St Louis Fed's yield and breakeven series and the New York Fed's term-premium file, both downloaded as data (p14); Omega's pages in five countries against the European Central Bank's rates for the same day (p10); two pull requests and their review threads (p8); and a British plc's annual report (p6). Computed here rather than quoted: the tracker-versus-Guard multiple on p3, the real-yield split on p14, the tax-stripped price comparison on p10, and the freight ratio on p22. Refused this desk today: Reddit on every route, which is why five desks print a null result rather than a sentiment; Marina Bay Sands and SISTIC; Hodinkee and the specialist tripod forums; the Nobel Foundation; and the database holding the Kava Act.